Rollcrate

Executive Summary: Rollcrate

Problem

Every semester, millions of college students move into and out of dorms. Most of them use whatever is cheap and available, like cardboard boxes, plastic bins, trash bags, and laundry baskets. These options are not great. Cardboard boxes tear and get soggy, plastic bins are bulky and hard to carry, and bags do not protect anything fragile. Students also have to carry heavy loads across parking lots, up stairs, and through crowded hallways, which is tiring and sometimes causes injuries. At the end of the year, many of these containers get thrown away, which is wasteful, and then students have to buy new ones the next fall.

A second problem is storage. Many students who live far from campus or study abroad need somewhere to keep their belongings over the summer. Storage companies and campus storage programs charge fees that can add up to a few hundred dollars a year, and students often feel they have no choice but to pay.

Solution

Rollcrate is a foldable storage crate with built-in wheels and a telescoping pull handle. When it is unfolded, it is a sturdy container that holds a large amount of clothing, books, bedding, and small electronics. When it is folded, it collapses to roughly the thickness of a textbook so it can slide under a bed, behind a door, or into a closet. The crate is made from a durable fabric-and-polymer material that is water resistant and designed to last for several years. Because it is reusable, students do not need to buy new boxes each year.

We believe Rollcrate also helps students save on storage. Because the crate is easy to pack, label, and stack, students can use cheaper options like a friend's garage or a shared unit, and some campuses may let students keep crates in their own storage rooms at reduced cost.

Market

There are about nineteen million college students in the United States, and a large share of them live on campus at some point. Our target is first and second year students who live in dorms and their parents, who often pay for the supplies. We estimate that about eight million students live in campus housing each year. If each of them spent forty dollars on a moving and storage product, that would be a market of around three hundred twenty million dollars. We think this is a reasonable estimate, though it is based on general assumptions rather than detailed research. Our first goal is to reach a small portion of this market, starting with schools near our own university and expanding to other regions.

Business Model

We plan to sell Rollcrate directly to students and parents through our website, with prices around thirty-five to forty-five dollars per crate and discounts for bundles of two or four. We also plan to sell through campus bookstores and through back-to-school promotions that connect with housing offices. A second revenue idea is to sell sponsored crates to universities and housing departments, which could give them to incoming students with a school logo on them. Our cost to make each crate is currently about eighteen dollars on a small production run, and we expect this to drop with larger orders. We have not yet tested all of these channels, and our pricing may change as we learn more from customers.

Competition

The space for dorm and moving products is crowded. There are many existing options, including plastic bins, rolling carts, collapsible crates, duffel bags with wheels, and large retail kits sold each August by big-box stores and online marketplaces. Some of these products are cheap, and some are well known. Our view is that none of them combines folding, wheels, and durability

in a single product that is designed specifically for the dorm move. Still, we know that larger companies could copy our idea, and that students are often price sensitive and may just choose the cheapest thing available. Our advantage is that we are focused on one customer and can move quickly, but we do not yet have a patent or strong brand.

Team

Marcus Delacroix-Ibarra is our CEO and handles overall strategy, customer conversations, and sales. He is a junior studying business and has experience working in a campus retail job. Priya Venkataraghavan leads product design and is a mechanical engineering student who built the first prototypes and manages relationships with our manufacturing contact. Tobias Ellingsworth is responsible for marketing and our website, and has experience running social media for a student club. Naomi Achterberg manages finances and operations, including our LLC paperwork and order tracking. We all attend our university and work on Rollcrate part time alongside classes.

Milestones and Financials

So far we have defined our core concept, registered Rollcrate as an LLC, built a working prototype, and launched a website. We gave early versions of the crate to a small number of students who tried them during a move-in weekend and gave us feedback, which was mostly positive, although some said the handle felt loose. We have also received our first payment from a customer, who purchased a set of crates through our website. Revenue to date is small, under a few hundred dollars. Our spending so far has come from the founders' own savings and a small amount of money from family, totaling about four thousand dollars, mostly for prototypes, the website, and legal filing fees.

Over the next twelve months, we plan to complete a first production run of about five hundred crates, improve the handle design, and sell mainly during the fall move-in season. We project revenue of roughly fifteen to twenty thousand dollars in the first year if sales go as planned, but this is a rough estimate and depends on how well our marketing works. We expect to be near break-even after the first production run and to need additional funds to grow beyond that.

What We Are Asking For

We are applying to this competition to win funding and to gain mentorship. We are hoping for a prize of around ten thousand dollars, which we would use mainly to pay for our first production run and to improve the product based on feedback. Beyond funding, we would value guidance from judges and advisors on pricing, how to approach university housing offices, and how to protect our design. We would also like introductions to manufacturers and to anyone with experience selling consumer products to students. We believe Rollcrate can make moving easier and cheaper for students, and we are excited to keep building it.